Policy Impact Assessment

LIHEAP & Food Assistance project, San Diego County · Study period January 2018 – July 2025

Summary

January–July 2023 is the most policy-disrupted period in the study, and it is the only period the validated LIHEAP data covers. In those months CalFresh households lost Emergency Allotments (an average of $163 a month in California), the federal COVID-19 Public Health Emergency ended, and SNAP work rules returned. LIHEAP enrollment in that window reflects a benefit cliff, not a typical baseline.

The food bank data (Jan 2018 – Aug 2025) is the only dataset that spans every policy period, so it is the main tool for comparing periods. The CalFresh data (Jan 2020 – Aug 2025) has only two pre-pandemic months, so it should be compared against 2024–2025 rather than a pre-pandemic baseline. This assessment gives the *expected* direction of each policy's effect and names the dataset that can test it; measured effects come from the analysis that follows.

1. Eligibility expansions and restrictions

LIHEAP's own eligibility did not change: 150% of the federal poverty guideline or 60% of state median income throughout. It moved indirectly, because CalFresh and CalWORKs households are automatically eligible for LIHEAP, so every CalFresh change also changes the pool of easily qualified LIHEAP applicants.

- **Expansion, June 2019:** SSI recipients became eligible for CalFresh, about 500,000 people statewide. Expected to raise enrollment, but it predates the CalFresh data, so only the food bank data can show indirect effects.
- **Expansion, 2020 – mid 2023:** pandemic waivers paused the work-rule time limit for adults without dependents (ABAWDs) and relaxed student rules, keeping more people enrolled.
- **Restriction, June–July 2023:** student exemptions ended and the able bodied adult without dependents time limit resumed July 1. Losses would show from late 2023, after the three-month limit, which is just after the LIHEAP window closes.
- **Mixed, September 2023 – October 2024:** the Fiscal Responsibility Act raised the work-rule age limit from 49 to 54 in steps, added exemptions for veterans, people experiencing homelessness and former foster youth, and cut state discretionary exemptions from 12% to 8% of the caseload.
- **Restriction, July 4, 2025:** the One Big Beautiful Bill Act extended work rules to ages 18–64 and removed the 2023 exemptions. It also ended automatic eligibility for the higher utility allowance through LIHEAP, except for households with an older adult or a person with a disability. This is the largest restriction in the study, but its effects mostly fall after the data ends.

2. Benefit levels and spending

CalFresh benefits rose in three steps and fell in one. Emergency Allotments (March 2020 – February 2023) raised every household to the maximum benefit, with at least $95 a month from April 2021; California issued about $14 billion to nearly 3 million households. A temporary 15% increase added about $27 per person per month from January to September 2021. The Thrifty Food Plan update permanently raised average benefits about 21% (about $36 per person per month) from October 2021. Then the end of Emergency Allotments cut household benefits by an average of $163 a month from April 2023, about $425 million a month statewide.

LIHEAP funding followed the same shape. National funding rose from $3.64 billion in FY2018 to about $8.25 billion in FY2021, then fell to $6.1 billion in FY2023 and $4.125 billion in FY2024–FY2025. California received about $49.5 million from the CARES Act and $204.4 million from the American Rescue Plan.

Expected spending patterns. When food benefits fall, households turn to food banks, so food bank demand should rise from April 2023, while San Diego prices were still up 6.4% over the year (January

2023). On the energy side, the winter 2022–23 natural gas price spike raised bills just before the LIHEAP window, and energy prices then fell 11.6% by January 2024. Higher LIHEAP demand in early 2023 would fit both the price spike and the food benefit loss.

3. Administrative changes

- **CalSAWS / BenefitsCal migration (2023, San Diego date to be confirmed):** system changes often cause temporary backlogs, so a 2023 dip or spike in CalFresh counts may reflect processing, not need.
- **End of pandemic processing waivers (May 11, 2023):** slower renewals and more churn are likely in mid-2023.
- **Two LIHEAP providers split by zip code (MAAC and Campesinos Unidos):** wait times can differ by provider, so group zip codes by provider before comparing them.
- **SDG&E arrears case-management pilot (December 2024 – April 2026):** may raise LIHEAP referrals in zip codes 92102, 92104, 92105, 92115 and 92116.
- **Chip EBT card rollout (late February – June 2025)** and **federal LIHEAP staff dismissals (April 2025, funds held until May 1):** possible short disruptions to benefit access and LIHEAP payments.

4. Pandemic emergency measures and sunset dates

Measure	In effect	Replaced by
Eviction protections (AB 3088, SB 91)	Mar 2020 – Jun 30, 2021	Rental and utility arrears assistance
Federal unemployment supplements	Mar 2020 – Sep 6, 2021	Regular state benefits
Temporary 15% SNAP increase	Jan – Sep 30, 2021	Permanent Thrifty Food Plan increase
Ban on gas and electric shutoffs (CPUC)	Mar 2020 – Sep 30, 2021	Payment plans; CAPP bill credits (2021, Nov 2022)
Extra federal LIHEAP funding (CARES, ARPA)	Mar 2020 – Sep 30, 2022	$100 million a year (Infrastructure Act)
CalFresh Emergency Allotments	Mar 2020 – Mar 26, 2023	Nothing (savings funded Summer EBT)
COVID-19 Public Health Emergency	Jan 2020 – May 11, 2023	Nothing; work rules resumed Jul 1, 2023

The sunsets were staggered: income and housing supports ended in 2021, but food benefits ran into 2023. The shutoff ban and debt credits deferred utility costs rather than removing them, so energy debt may have carried into 2022–2023.

5. Most and least affected periods

Period	Impact	Why	Data available
Jan 2018 – Feb 2020	**Low**	Stable rules; only the 2019 SSI expansion.	Food bank
Mar 2020 – Sep 2021	**Highest (expansion)**	Up to eight relief measures at once (March 2021); unemployment hit a record 16.1%.	Food bank, CalFresh
Oct 2021 – Dec 2022	**Medium**	Income, housing and utility relief over; food benefits still high; inflation 8.2% (Jan 2022); gas price spike late 2022.	Food bank, CalFresh
Jan – Jul 2023	**Highest**	Allotments and the health emergency end; work and	Food bank, CalFresh,

Period	Impact	Why	Data available
	(contraction)	student rules return; CalSAWS migration.	LIHEAP
Aug 2023 – Dec 2024	**Medium**	Work-rule age limit rises; LIHEAP funding falls; Tropical Storm Hilary and the January 2024 flood.	Food bank, CalFresh
Jan – Jul 2025	**Medium, rising**	EBT card replacement, LIHEAP staffing cuts, then the July 2025 SNAP restrictions.	Food bank, CalFresh

Least affected: January 2018 – February 2020, the natural baseline for the food bank data. **Most affected:** March 2020 – September 2021 and January – July 2023; neither should be treated as normal in comparisons.

6. Limitations and next steps

- **Short baselines.** CalFresh and LIHEAP have no usable pre-pandemic period; use the food bank data for period comparisons.
- **The LIHEAP window is the benefit cliff.** Don't generalize January–July 2023 findings to other years. Recovering zip codes from August 2023 onward would allow a before-and-after comparison.
- **Tests to run next:** whether food bank demand rose from April 2023; whether CalFresh enrollment fell after July 2023; whether LIHEAP enrollment differs by provider area.
- **To confirm:** San Diego's CalSAWS go-live date, and whether the state-funded food benefit (CFAP) expansion took effect within the study period.

Sources: policy details, dates and figures are from the project's Policy_Changes_Inventory and External_Factors_Log, which cite the original sources.